

Power Tips

Step-by-step procedure for installation of a graphic card

As new games are released, one feels the need upgrade to a newer generation of graphics cards. If you would like to move to a new graphics card but are not sure how to go about successfully installing it, these tips will prove useful.

Before opening the cabinet and pulling out your old graphics card, uninstall the drivers for the old graphics card from the Control Panel. Now, shut down the computer and open up the cabinet carefully. Remove the VGA connector attaching your monitor to your video card. Pull out the old graphics card carefully. Hunt for the AGP slot (which is brown in colour and smaller than white PCI slots).

Now you can insert the new graphics card into the brown slot and screw it in tightly. Close the cabinet and switch on the computer. The card should be recognised by Windows, and Windows will install the basic VGA drivers.

When asked to install the drivers for the card, choose No, and continue. Insert the driver disk provided with the card and follow the on-screen instructions to install the drivers for the card. Restart your machine and your new graphic card should be installed successfully.

In case your graphic card does not come with the driver software, you can download generic detonator drivers if your card has an nVidia Video Chipset (find them online at www.nvidia.com), the Catalyst drivers if you have an ATi-chipset based card (www.ati.com), or Matrox drivers if so required by your card (www.matrox.com)

Watching TV on your PC

Watch television on your PC! This is one more step towards making the personal computer the centre of all your activities. Apart from live telecast, TV tuner cards come with other capabilities like recording and playback, making television viewing more flexible than ever before. The hardware consists of an AV/Tuner Box, and cables that connect it to the video card. The coaxial cable goes into the tuner box instead of in the back of your TV.

Personal Video Recording (PVR) software lets you preview TV channels and encode the broadcast into MPEG 1 or MPEG 2 video format in real time. It also allows you to record your

favourite program in case you're busy at the time of the telecast. You can then watch the recorded program at your convenience. The time-shifting feature allows you to pause, replay or skip live TV without interrupting an ongoing recording session. This feature allows you to take a break while watching a live show, and resume where you left off. You can also capture stills.

However, keep in mind that storing movies in MPEG format takes up considerable space. The memory requirement will depend on the quality of the recording. For example, a one-

minute MPEG-2 file recorded at 720 x 480 resolution and a good bit rate would take up about half a gigabyte of memory. So think twice before you record interminable TV soaps, especially if storage space is scarce. In any case, you will definitely need a CD-RW drive to archive your recordings.

There's usually a user-friendly control panel for performing all these functions. A fully functional remote is also provided with some models like the Compro VideoMate. The installation process is quite simple, and is clearly explained in the

user's manual. Get a large, high-resolution PC monitor—and leave it to your PVR to record your favourite program while you read this article!

Speakers

Optimum Speaker Placement

To get the best out of your home theatre system, place the left and right speakers along the width of your room. From where you are going to sit, the front speakers should be approximately 60 degrees apart from each other with the listener at the reference central position. The rear speakers should form a 110-degree angle from this reference position.

For optimum effect, the four speakers should be kept at (or slightly above) ear level. You can place the subwoofer anywhere. If you find that the bass in your system is a little low, place the subwoofer facing a wall, preferably in a corner of the room.

If the surround sound channels are too faint, 'toe-in' the surround speakers so that they point towards the listener. Conversely, if they are too prominent, place them facing the wall as this helps disperse the sound from the rear channels, resulting in a more enveloping effect.

